before straightening late. I run towards him, this time the stumps making an earthier, more satisfying sound of a small apocalypse. I glare at him as he leaves.

The next ball and last of the over, I find the exact same ball again – this time it's to Travis Friend. I feel so sure of it and it feels so right that I give myself time to enjoy its flight, to see it shaping in the air, the ball rotating backwards on its axis but moving forwards, spearing and swerving, but totally upright as if it is still – the seam is so straight, so pronounced. Friend does the same as Streak, Yousuf and the other club cricketers; he offers to hit it down the leg side before realising it is ill-judged. It's too late. There are two more: Andy Blignaut, spun around and edging the ball to Mark Butcher, then Douglas Hondo, cleaned up and bowled with the off stump flying out of the ground.

I feel like I can bowl any ball that day. If I was any older or more experienced, I'd refuse to let the ball get taken off me. It's as if, since that first day back in the nets at Burnley, every day had just been propelling me towards this moment, bowling exactly the same type of balls that had been sent to me that day, but this time in the biggest arena of them all. When they put my name up on the Lord's honours board, I have to blink a few times at it to be sure it was there: Anderson 16–4–73–5. A part of me wants to take the permanent marker out of the hands of the member of staff putting it up there (at first on tape as a placeholder, waiting to be chiselled in) and write my name and five at the bottom of the list on Darren Gough's bag. I wanted to be on that bag too.

I was up and running. As I left the ground, I heard the chant again, the certification of being someone else: 'Oh, Jimmy Jimmy,' they all sang, 'Jimmy, Jimmy, Jimmy, Jimmy Anderson.' I felt like I wasn't Jimmy Anderson any more and instead was James from Burnley again as soon as I was thrown in front of the television and radio reporters. I had not done anything but local radio before. I gave them one-word answers, nervously twitching, eyes cast down, unsure of what they wanted to hear from me, just wishing to have the ball in my hand again.